London Plane

A Radio Play

by Rowan Martin

Part One:
Pagans

Prologue

[_FIREWORKS_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

Finger-pink gravel in the night sky
Being poured down our necks
Sour masonry
Under the Great Road's mouth
Tingling in our heels
Toxic greens mewing
Firework lights of Diwali
Paraffin tastes
Phosphoring our hair
Like the leaves of the planes
Storing carbon from adjacent parties
Magic cards turned over by wind
Locked up and re-releasing
At this time of year
A saffron bird spreading its tail-feathers
Sowing wheat-fields in the dark
To remind us of the first time
To remind us of streaming roads
Slimy windows from which we came.

I. Queen of Wands

[_MORNING BIRDS_]

THE NARRATOR

This story is a fish's skeleton
Ribs of intrigue
Coming off a clear spine
Bony lanes digressing off a single street
And the chunks of that vertebrae
Are the history of Dawn
Witchdoctor, bone-setter
Sage of the flower-boxes
The Queen of Wands
Here she comes now
Arriving into the pub car park
In her summer-fly green car
Through strings of paradise [_CAR DOOR CLOSING_]

DAWN *(Singing)*

If I don't see her each day, I miss her
Oh gee what a thrill to kiss her
It seems that I've got a case
Of Nancy

THE NARRATOR

She sports a murdered beehive
And an orange-mottled chest
That clicks with chrome and crystals as she walks
Friday morning on Plane Street [_CATS MEWING_]
And the cats are sleeping on the forecourt
Powdery rain smudges the lights
Over the old pub sign
The Queen of Wands
A daffodil-gowned queen
On a throne of callous sunflowers
Behind her a feathered vista
Of yellow dunes in triangles

DAWN *(clearing)*

What did I say
What do I *always* say
No glasses left outside after the lock-in

THE NARRATOR

She picks up the rain-soda'd whiskeys
Gets out her bouquet of keys
And opens up the pub [_UNLOCKING DOOR_]
Inside, planks of ocean light impale the drapes
Laser a jar of pickles
Still in darkness
She puts the straggler-glasses on the bar
And tiptoes to the top shelf
Where, behind the single malts and sambuccas
She keeps her tin of fortunes
A French Tarot deck
Of major and minor arcana
She purchased on a road trip to Nice many years before
She slides into a moody booth
Contemplates the empty pub, rising up with its yeasty histories
Its slumbering fruit machines
And begins

DAWN *(shuffling)*

Before I begin this reading
I call upon the spiritual guides to surround me
With love, light, and protection
I ask that only energies of the highest good be present during this reading

THE NARRATOR

Splaying the cards in a fan of mystery paisley
Dawn taps the table thrice
Her knuckles spiced with last night's citrus spray [_THREE TAPS_]
One card seems to suggest itself
She turns it over

DAWN *(reading)*

'Justice'
'Reverse'

THE NARRATOR

A judge dangles from a set of scales like children's balloons
Meanwhile squared jolts of wood
Being chucked into a skip can be heard
Echoing from where workmen are gutting
The old ice cream shop two doors down.

[_BUILDING WORK_]

II. Justice - Reverse

[_SCHOOL KIDS_]

THE NARRATOR

All through the scaly spring
Azram had worked on building the verandah, the thing
That would set *Sensations*
Apart from the other sweet parlours in the area, with patience
Came reward and on the first
Hot day of the year, when the cars went mad and the wind burst
On the yellow locust trees
The year 11s arrived from the *Hillbottom High*, knees
Covered politely as they sat
Under parasols of virtue, Az listened to their chat

HILLBOTTOM KID 1

She's just some posh girl from Hilltop trying to be street

HILLBOTTOM KID 2

Innit, she is nice though…

THE NARRATOR

The waffle-iron whispered
Through its locked jaw as tundras of ice cream blistered
Vanilla, strawberry
Chocolate mint, a palette of wounded pastels, Az's law degree
Hung among hygiene certificates on the wall
Some had suggested *Sensation*s to be a front, but as July crawled
into a frantic jog
The verandah became a populous oasis, and out of the street's dry bog
Came schoolkids, Poles, petty dealers, lovers
Clinging to its beached deck under geometries of shade, brothers
Lounging in the medina
Until night fall, when blue icicles of neon cast the patina
Of an ice station onto the powdered kerb
Beneath polar skies, Azram cleared chocolate-marbled plates, served
His nephew Daud and his crew
Of boy racers: in a camo Merc all evening they'd vroom [_CAR ENGINE_]

DAUD

What's good uncle? Set me and my boys some cones out here

AZRAM

OK, but no trouble now

THE NARRATOR

They shook the genteel side streets
Stealing sleep and value from houses as they ate their arctic sweets
They were a nuisance not a menace
But then on the hottest night that year, when Plane Street was Veniced
By a burst water main [_WATER FLOWING_]
And the moon became an alligator's misted lens, a train
Of rival lads - the Cinammon Dock Boys -
Rolled into *Sensations,* they duelled eyebrows, ice creams poised

CINNAMON DOCK BOY 1

Free country innit
Me and my boys just getting some shakes

DAUD

Just remember to respect the premises
This my uncle's place yeah?

THE NARRATOR

Someone pushed past
Someone else and before long the cool mast
Of a Carte D'Or parasol [_SCUFFLE STARTS_]
Rattled as a fight broke out on deck, pirates on a verandah, a Pole
Stepped in to break up the ruckus
Az rushed out, Daud chasing after rivals

AZRAM

Little fuckers!

[_SILENCE_]

[_MORNING BIRDS_]

THE NARRATOR

Azram drove back in the morning
To a shipwrecked verandah gouged by cannonballs, the awning
A torn sail on a ripped galleon
The Cinnamon Boys had gone back for reverse justice, savaging
Azram's minor oasis
In the back fridge he cried among Nutella, London's desert list
Was about to grow bigger
He turned out the lights on his headache holographic mural of Mecca
And in a few months sold up
Broken as the verandah's ribs, but somehow he rolled up
His sleeves
And out of the ruined sorbet refroze a new dream

[_BUILDING WORK RESUMES_]

AZRAM

New Sensations, Milton Keynes.

III. The High Priestess

[_LIGHT MUSIC_]

THE NARRATOR

Pineapple and cheese totem poles
Chicken tikka sacrifices
Pickled onions like frog's eyeballs
Dawn brings out trays like offerings
On a feast day for a neopagan festival
Officiated by her, landlady of the ivy's
The Wicca of the Wands
She arranges them on the bar
Covers with cling film and a sacred A4 reading

DAWN

Reserved for the family of Tony 1

THE NARRATOR

The radio plays a late 80s ballad
Whose crystal synths gleam and crack
Like ice in a vodka tonic [_ICE MELTING_]
Dawn's morning stiffener
Or the gems around her neck
Moonstone
Bloodstone
Blue agate, a geology of luck
Dawn, since the beginning of the day
Since the beginning of all days
Is Plane Street's miracle elder
Its high priestess and shaman
Psychic, agony aunt, sometime healer of a local judo champ
Medium to regulars, occasionals,
Even the errant French and Japanese tourists
Who had wandered down Plane Street's fossilised parade
And into the arms of the Wands

DAWN *(Glancing at clock)*

Five to twelve
Just time for another throw

THE NARRATOR

With the food spread complete
She goes back to her cards
Gathering them up like feathers or fish scales
Sacred animal materials
Reshuffling the deck
Like the broken up verandah down the street
Reincarnating its ribs
Into a paisley future
She taps again [_THREE TAPS_]
But before she reveals her next card
In comes the day's first (and probably last) regular [_FRONT DOOR GOES_]

PETER

Morning Dawnie

DAWN

Morning Peter, just be a moment

THE NARRATOR

A shabby hawk in a leather waistcoat
Peter enters in his eel-funked waders
Greyhound lurching in front of him
Fresh from the canals where he resides
Secretly, Dawn flips over the card

DAWN

'The Fool'

THE NARRATOR

A garish clown with a bladder of possessions
Standing with a dog on a serrated cliff-edge
Forgetting that Dawn sees everything
Peter helps himself to a sausage roll from the spread.

IV. The High Priestess

[_WATER LAPPING_]

THE NARRATOR

On his beloved *Sloe Gin* Peter snoozed
Under a sandy sky
And iceberg clouds
Seagulls stood like sentries
On the warehouse rooves
Their candied *M*
Folded like origami
Into the canal's stirred symmetry
Inverted in the water's crease
In a honeyed *W*
The warehouse rooves
Dripped down, seagulls
Hung off them like bats
Over capsized clouds
And Peter snoozing in the cabin of *Sloe Gin*

PETER *(Dreaming)*

Gooh! Gah! Where we going?

THE NARRATOR

He dreamt of a coast somewhere [_CRASHING WAVES_]
With a woman he once knew
Whispering kelp-smell strengthening
As he followed her to the tangy wreck of a sunset
Over a silicon sea
She took him down from the skully crags
To a place where they stood in the surf [_WAVES INTENSIFY_]
Tubes of living sand, dreamy salt around their knees
She kissed him and began to undo her dress
But then he felt something slimy at his heels

[_WAVES ABATE TO LAPPING_]

PETER *(gargling)*

No…What's that? Don't stop! Agh!

THE NARRATOR

Peter woke up
A greyhound licking at his feet
Its tongue had trespassed into his dream

PETER *(angry)*

Ah Lizzie! I was just getting to the good bit

LIZZIE

Woof!

THE NARRATOR

He shooed Lizzie away
The georgian-brick coloured hound
His companion of the canals
And tried to resume his interrupted dream
10 minutes later he was up [_POTS AND PANS_]
Grogging and lurching around the cabin of Sloe Gin
Rocking her comically in the canal's gelled water
With each hungover stride
Searching for coffee and rollies

PETER *(to Lizzie)*

What do you want now? I tell you, you're Queen Liz these days

THE NARRATOR

He mashed up last night's beans
Pulled on his waistcoat and waders
And went up deck into the blaze of day [_BIRDSONG_]

Sloe Gin shone like a magician's box in the combed weeds of the water
Pub-green, wax-red, daffodil-yellow
Its panels were braided with the UFO of a druid's cross
Peter yawned and stepped onto the springy, appled bank
Smelt the furry dew of morning
Heard the Great Road grinding [_CARS_]
The wires of the pylons strung over the canal
Shook like mandolin strings in the wind
Lizzie came out to sit on the grass as he went to work fooling today's Romans
This time a dresser made of 'California Spruce'
In fact what he'd found in a skip outside the old ice cream shop [_SANDING_]

PETER *(working)*

Peter, Captain *Sloe,* goes around
Duping Romans with old bits he's found
Yew wood knot cedar
Difference so Peter
Goes home flush - but not proud!

V. Wheel of Fortune

[_FRUIT MACHINES_]

PETER

Bag of gold please Dawnie

THE NARRATOR

Dawn goes into the safe room
Exchanges a bag of twenty ones
For Peter's algae'd note
She hands him the bladder of coins
Like the fool's sack of possessions

DAWN

DO spend it all at once

THE NARRATOR

He goes over to the fruit machines
Chinese fireworks snake around their dials, casinoing brains
Rolling with concussive clovers, airship diamonds, svelte cherries

Wheels of fortune
He starts to play

PETER

Eye of Horus

[_EGYPTIAN MELODY_]

THE NARRATOR

Foaming pyramids rise
Out of plasma dunes
He descends into a rendered crypt
Dropping 10 ones in its tomb
Peter the pharaoh, Egyptian'd by sun
Lizzie sat beside him, sphinx'd by canal rays
Both mummified in the pub's settling silt
Next he tries

PETER

Luck of the Irish

[_IRISH REEL_]

THE NARRATOR

Fragrant quilts of Ireland interlock
Under a blue legend of skies
A scripted leprechaun dances to a rover
From a queasy tin whistle
Hides Peter's bag of gold under the machine's rainbowed dials

LEPRECHAUN

Game over! Ha ha ha - top of the mornin'!

PETER

Oh go top *yourself*

THE NARRATOR

Meanwhile Dawn takes a photo of the spread for the evening's wake
Forwards it on to Tony 2

DAWN

All ready for you when you get here
Love, D

THE NARRATOR

The corals of her phone in the pub's tomb
Reef the Irish shallows of her face

And so the Queen of Wands comes to life
Open for business to anyone
Brave, romantic or oblivious enough to cross its threshold
The wind cellos in the car park forecourt
Performing a séance of crisp packets
Shivering through the whitened grass
The builders gutting *Sensations* down tools for a midday breakfast
Dawn spreads her tarot deck again
On the bar's scented altar
The site of aeons of grain-soaked rituals

[_THREE TAPS_]

DAWN

'Page of Swords'

THE NARRATOR

Silence
Save for the gale in her nostrils
As she inspects the vibrating card
A knight holding a cutlass in stockings the colour of daffodils
Meanwhile out in the muted street
The harps of a Japanese willow teem with pixels.

VI. Page of Swords

[_ LIGHT WIND, RAIN_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

Your soul is immortal, your teachings will never
Be forgotten by us, RIP Tony,
Plane Street forever

THE NARRATOR

White tributes tattooed the shop shutters and flowers
Bled on the pavement outside *Plane Street Dojo*. Hours
Had passed since the death of Tony 1 from cancer
Of the oesophagus, and Dawn, the amateur necromancer
Had already tried to undo his ending, but to no avail
The old Sensei was sleeping eternally, soon a trail
Of mourners arrived outside the dead man's shop
Under a chain mail of willow, teardrops
Of rain that leoparded the street were repelled
And the makeshift shrine kept dry, no tears welled

In the ducts of his son, Tony 2, when he arrived

TONY 2

Fuck me that was a long old schlep

THE NARRATOR

Back to the old neighbourhood from the English coast
A necessary inconvenience, he had no time for fatherly ghosts
But when he opened up the shop, the ambered supplies [_OPENING SHUTTERS_]
Of budo mats (max strength) and school uniforms gave him a surprise
Attack of nostalgia, the Bruce Lee posters, walls studded
With English sportswear logos, like cave paintings in a flooded
Antechamber - suddenly he heard his father singing - and the absent noise
Japanesed into karate,
[_GONG_]

TONY 2

His empty fist

THE NARRATOR

And karaoke

TONY 2

His empty voice

THE NARRATOR

In the stockroom upstairs, Tony 2 turned his feelings off [_MOVING BOXES_]
And proceeded with his mission: liquefy the stock
Sell off the family silver and leave Plane Street for good
His eBay listings included throwing stars, a cedar-wood
Set of nunchucks, he found a mystery box of items by the sill
Of the stairs, its contents unoxidised for years until
With the slip of the finger a safety pin was unprized

TONY 2

Fucking aaaaaada [_CRASHING ITEMS_]

THE NARRATOR

And the trivia of 40 years spilt out of it, a shale slide
Flowing down the steps and into the Dojo hall
Tony's despair quickly mutated into wonder, for all [_SILENCE_]
The fragments of his cosmos were spread out beside him
With the clarity of near-death he inspected each item
In the vomited museum: an ancient photo of his great aunt Dorry
Next to a recent girlfriend, like London buildings, an untidy quarry
A natural history dynamited out of chronology
The pulsar of a blank CD balanced upon a book on sociology
He read for his degree (for some reason Dad must've kept)

And his Uni ID, whitening like a polaroid in reverse, his steps
Were unsteady as he descended the landfill of memory
Down to the landing, where he was struck down by a resiny
Smell of paper stuffed away, and a strange drawing of muddled
Samurai swords, by himself aged 6, he wept in priceless rubble

TONY 2

Sensei…Londoner…Dad…

[_GONG, WIND, LIGHT RAIN_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

A hateful heart is one that never knew love
And a black belt is white belt that never gave up.

VII. The Lovers

[_GARDEN HOSE_]

THE NARRATOR

Buddhas are charred wet in their rainforested shelves
As Dawn hoses down flower-boxes in the Shangri-la
Of her beer garden
Tangoing shrubs and percussive bamboos shake their heads
She shreds
Icicles of light into rainbows
As her waterfall bends
Over the pink patio's panting grooves
Enter Peter, coming out for a fag with Lizzie

PETER *(Lighting up)*

What time's the ceremony today Dawn?

DAWN

4 o' clock I think, cemetery at 2

PETER

I wondered if I should put something on

DAWN

No, you'll be alright
Tony's not the sentimental type

THE NARRATOR

Lizzie scrabbles around the wet patio
Licking puddles and sniffing quenched flowers
The white gramophone of an anemone
Trembles in the breeze
The scoring of cars from the Great Road can be heard [_CARS_]
A stylus on a vinyl skein
Enter Lyle & Aisha, a middle-aged couple [_GARDEN DOOR GOES_]
He sports a sea-flecked goatee and receding coastline of hair
She is tortoise-faced with chlorine eyes
Both dressed up
He speaks in the music of old Plane Street
With a subtle commonwealth accompaniment

LYLE

Afternoon all, how are we?
Just stopping by before the cemetery
Fruity took your ones again Peter?

PETER *(Gruffly)*

Yep, yep, yep

DAWN

Afternoon both, don't you look nice?

AISHA *(Cheerfully)*

Spread looks great Dawn, need any help with it?

DAWN

No thanks, all set
Just give my love to Tony 2 and tell him we'll be here waiting for him

LYLE *(Checking watch)*

I make that just time for a quickie
Guinness for me and a…

AISHA

Vodka and coke

LYLE

V and C for the lady,
Please Dawn

THE NARRATOR

Dawn heads back inside and starts the Guinness [_PINT POURING_]
A funeral-suit of stout with a white collar, like a miniature of Lyle

While she waits for its canal silt to settle
She flips another card [_THREE TAPS_]

DAWN

'The Moon'
The moon…

THE NARRATOR

Two dogs play on a spongey river bank as the moon smiles down
A lobster crawls between them
She glances into the garden
Peter the star-crustacean, between Lyle and Aisha's sky chart.

VIII. The Moon

[_COMPUTER TYPING_]

THE NARRATOR

Www.loveinthestars.com
Category: Mature
Background: Afro-Caribbean British
Interests: Dancing, Food, Tennis
Lyle had met all of Aisha's criteria
And the stars of the internet had co-operated late last year
To marry their twin spheres
She sat wilting among office fronds
At her travel agent's job
Slyly admiring Lyle's glittering dating profile
On loveinthestars.com

LYLE

50 something black cockney
Looking for dancing, fun, memories and maybe more

THE NARRATOR

She floated their compatibility on starry reefs
Lyle, the Capricorn with his sea-goatee
Aisha, Cancer's crab with her pincered earrings
Between their empty tropics and motifs
They met at the equator
A curry-house of his choice in Cinammon Dock
To join islands (hers Barbados, his Jamaica)

AISHA [_GOING INSIDE RESTAURANT_]

Oooh la-la-la, fancy

LYLE

Only the best for a lady
Plus I know the bossman

THE NARRATOR

Under a yammering rainforest of unripe car alarms [_FAR OFF CAR ALARMS_]
They sat in Lyle's date haunt, *The Taste of Bangalore* [_LIGHT INDIAN MUSIC_]
Emptied of other Friday night diners like a private clam
It's blue delta murals mermaided Aisha's dress
The mature romantics talked in its fenugreeked columns
Its booths folded like an address book

AISHA [_BREAKING POPPADOMS_]

It's been a while since I've dated
It was my sister encouraged me to get back out there

LYLE

Well I'm glad she did
You're too good to stay on the shelf, that's for sure

THE NARRATOR

Love's kindles came in sizzling on a tandoor trolley
While the incantations of the manager taking delivery addresses
Transported them beyond those postcodes

MANAGER

Tango whiskey two…

THE NARRATOR

A beachside tipple in their 80s pomp

MANAGER

Echo sierra november…

THE NARRATOR

The cold mountain ranges of their divorces

MANAGER

Hotel delta…

THE NARRATOR

Now back to Aisha's for coffee (and no more)
In her muddy galleon flat in Cinammon Dock

The moon cast a beach of yellow and blue onto them [_LIGHT ROMANTIC MUSIC_]
Filtered through her Barbadian flag
Silhouetting its sandy trident on their faces
As they danced to Luther and Whitney, Alexander O'Neal
Then at midnight Lyle kissed her chivalrously

LYLE

It was great to meet you Miss Cancer

THE NARRATOR

And headed back to Plane Street
But not before stopping by the basin
To drink up the evening
The smell of wet clay [_CITY AT NIGHT, WATER_]
Burgeoning romance in a purple humdrum sky
He watched a lamp drop polyps of light
Onto the gecko'd hand of a plane
Meanwhile Aisha studied London's astrology from her balcony
Constellations of crane-lights from the new flats going up
Foretelling a new skyline
Planes skated over her rock-pool eyes like manta rays
From her discoed court she beheld the fish-oil moon
Suds of late night birds squeaking

AISHA [_WINDCHIMES_]

You too Mr Capricorn, you too

THE NARRATOR

Within weeks there was talk of a cruise
A Caribbean getaway
Aisha had received a tip-off on a deal
But for now they would keep their London weather
Love had changed the climate of their days.

IX. Ace of Cups

[_LIGHT TALK RADIO_]

THE NARRATOR

Aisha and Lyle, the crow-couple fly off for the ceremony
Dredged mud sits at the bottom of his Guinness
Like the bed of the canal
Aisha's vodka glass is a cold sweat of ice
And condensation
Silence thickens once again in the Queen of Wands

Peter stalks back in from the toilet [_TOILET FLUSHING_]

PETER

Here, what's that notice in the gents all about Dawnie?

DAWN

Noise complaints, some Roman in the new flats
Across the basin
Doesn't like my seances and my music
She won't identify herself, of course

PETER

They never do
Prefer to remain anonymous

DAWN

I don't get why they've always gotta go crying to top brass
Why not come and speak to me directly?
We've been here 350 years
Those flats have been up five minutes
And she wants us to change to *her* image?

THE NARRATOR

Peter shakes his head performatively
Drains his glass and signals for another
The Ace of Cups himself
His drinking had been unrivalled in his day
22 pints in one session his most
That was when the *Wands* was still a rocking place
Before all the old Plane Streeters died
Or one by one took the bribes of passageways to the coast
He had been the life and soul back then
Emanating a kind of unstable pisshead warmth
Now it was just him and Lizzie
Sometimes Lyle and Aisha, Dawn

RADIO NEWS REPORTER

A turf war between the CD Boys and Plane Street Gang
Came to a head here...
The 19 year old was airlifted to Great Road Hospital [_INTERFERENCE_]
Police are asking anyone with information to come forward

PETER

Bloody kids, better off letting them all kill each other
That's what I say!

THE NARRATOR

Dawn hears but doesn't register
Her eyes are back on her cards, the last of the morning

[_THREE TAPS_]

DAWN

'The Chariot'

THE NARRATOR

A saintly knight is drawn by cart out to a pickled city's edge
From the Great Road cars can be heard slipping off London's ledge.

X. The Chariot

[_MOTORWAY_]

THE NARRATOR

Coming back from Milton Keynes
The sails of the scrapyards were chequered flags, their rags
Of old skip nets
Forming a finishing line for Azram's beamer, streamers
Made up a grand prix
As he turned off a slip, down Basin Way, where a stray
Red pony stood blinking
In a swollen field, bowing to pick weeds out of pink rubble, Az double
Parked on a lay-by
And went to feed it, but it would not move, the grooves
Of off-road tyres
Scarred its churned paddock, its terracotta fur raving, like the hot paving
Of the sky was scrawled with pink chalk

AZRAM

Here boy, here
What's up with you?

THE NARRATOR

From there Az walked down the wild London lane, his photo-degraded brain
A dry ocean
Of heath and ferns, nettles eating a mattress's corpse, thoughts
Of his dead shop
Daud who in the prevailing gang chase had driven off London's lip, ripped
The zip of his vertebrae
In the dying day, he arrived at a pylon's shrine, where slime
And tart fish smells stained the breeze
From the recycling plants, he stood under a electrified bones, in tones
Of cool shade

AZRAM

You stupid *arse*hole!

[_NIGHT MOTORWAY_]

THE NARRATOR

Night splashing around him now, he reached the Great Roundabout, a redoubt
Of palms and island steel
Where Daud, chasing after the CD Boys had misjudged, fudged
A curve and plunged the camo Merc
Into the reservoir's fields of water, doubling Az's tragedy, casually
He reached the island's strand
And watched over other boy racers doing their stunts, lunar runts
Surfing over frozen waves
They all could've been Daud on another day, he prayed
For them and their uncles too

AZRAM

Wa alaykum as-salam
Peace be upon you

THE NARRATOR

He remembered the helicopter had landed on the pony field, raised his peeled
Body up to the horizon [_HELICOPTER_]
As witch's music thrashed in the curtains of trees, the chopped breeze
Cleansed hairs off his face [_HELICOPTER DIES OFF_]
And Az looked out, a pylon shrouded in steam like a shuttle, subtle
Derricks of mini-pylons behind [_CARS RETURN_]
The moving tape of the Great Road, sequinned with cars and vans, and
From beyond the reservoir's curved bay
Where the red pony slept under clouds of corrugated beach, peach
Industrial lights strained with
All his lawyers' calculations, impossible tangles forming, as swarming
Racers flew over Jurassic roads
Az turned his back on the basin and Plane Street, the sale was complete
He went back to his beamer
Set new co-ordinates in the GPSs star-chart

AZRAM

London - good riddance!

THE NARRATOR

For interstellar England.

[_CARS FADE TO RADIO INTERFERENCE, THEN SILENCE.]

Part Two:

Romans

Prologue

[_DEMOLITION_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

Robbers of the world, having by their universal plunder
Exhausted the land, they rifle the deep
If the enemy be rich, they are rapacious
If he be poor, they lust for dominion
Neither the east nor the west has been able to satisfy them
Alone among men they covet with equal eagerness poverty and riches
To robbery, slaughter, plunder, they give the lying name of empire
Where they make a desert, they call it peace

[_SILENCE_]

XI. Queen of Cups

[_HEAVY RAIN_]

THE NARRATOR

Pods of rain thicken
High in the plane trees' oblate brains
Whose synapses shiver as water leaks
Through their leaves like a thought
Or the sweaty sapphire of a siren
Rolling down Tony 2's forehead, as he sits
Warm and uncomfortable in *Morrisons Funerals*
The balmy sunrise of a healing crystal spills
Over the Flanders Fields
Of its Remembrance Day displays
An icing of red poppies
On an astroturf birthday cake

TONY 2

Lest we forget, Plane Street remembers

THE NARRATOR

A few feet away, runaway tears begin in a sycamore
Baptising druid Peter
Retrieving more gold out of the Precinct cashpoint
Christening Lizzie's animal soul shaking beside him
Consecrating Pictish Dawn
As she sets down a six of cups
To catch leaks dripping from the *Queen of Wands*' ceiling

Exorcising Lyle and Aisha
Halloween'd by a black umbrella on their way to the *Five Acres Cemetery*
Just beyond its perimeter, the canal fries in the downpour
Prickling the light-trawled hull of *Sloe Gin*
Lanterns of other narrowboats nodding in the swell [_BOATS ROCKING_]
Of wine-bottle water rising and racing
Carrying its payload of duck feathers and football buoys
Down to the basin at Cinammon Dock
Where it slaps against the bearded weirs [_MOSS SLAPPING_]
Birch trees and premonitions of new flats televised
In the lagoon's butterscotch display

UNKNOWN VOICE

New homes by Romans Developments
Penthouses available

THE NARRATOR

Life at the foot of the tall banks, cunards docked on flower-jetties
By Himalayan headquarters blinking sorely
In whose shadow snooze slugs of salons, curry-houses,
Washing-line shrines in another fossilised parade
The Taste of Bangalore
Millennium Stores
Meanwhile in *TK's Dry-Clean / Laundrette*
An intensive cycle finishes up
Of loathing and refreshing
Rinsing laundry with the water of the sacred canal
Spun dry on the sorcery of the Great Road
Then the murmuring smell from the baskets
Like the phenomenal piles of leaves, soggy plankton under park trees
Raunchy compounds of rot and freshness on the wind
Passages to autumn, like a showered mop's bracken
A familiar flyer reads

UNKNOWN VOICE

Where they make a desert, they call it peace

THE NARRATOR

She's still a revolutionary, I see
I stand outside refreshing my phone
Still no word from Alice
So I read up on popular tarot card meanings
Posted by *D-Wands*
Which one am I?
How about 'The Hermit':

‘A lonely wanderer transfixed by a blue lantern’
I walk on, over Cinammon Dock’s slug-black bridges
Winding between its slave-trade gables
A brittle confetti of blue and pink
Powdery downpour flaking my screen.

XII. The Hermit

[_PHONE VIDEOS_]

THE NARRATOR

Three tabs, in sparks of rain, a triptych of my brain
Tab one [_FOOTBALL CHEER_]
A London derby in still life, after the equaliser, before the winner
Tab two
A landscape of a geomapped headland near Nansemond, Virginia [_OCEAN_]
Tab three
A portrait of Alice, frozen in a social media winter [_ICY WIND_]

ALICE

Save Plane Street from Romans colonisers
Where they make a desert, they call it peace

THE NARRATOR

Read her caption
Televisual textiles of fake flowers throbbed on the bridge [_CARS_]
A flicking shrine to some fallen racer
And past the escarpment of bony houses
I watched the contraflow of blood cell lights
The shell-swell of car oceans rolling through the gorge
In dogshit season
An awakening ambulance electrocuted me, alleged poet, [_AMBULANCE_]
Hermit, lifetime wanderer out of the murderous torpor
Of London days when the sky is a torn-off envelope
Of grey and white mixed identities and no
Serenity can be found, not even in the
Plaza of Virginia Yard
Where heavy machinery and [_MACHINERY_]
Sulphurous grinders impured the
Waterfalls of its lobby

UNKNOWN VOICE

New homes by Romans Developers

Penthouses available

THE NARRATOR

I walked on
Down the highway of Cinammon Dock
Arms tucked in, as if to minimise my existence
The typical din of torn-off days, the torn-off pages
Of poetry scrapbooks, the torn-open letters of red-lipped banality
Torn-open sandwiches consumed on benches outside schools
Aching with yellow leaves, September'd with kids
There, all us daytime hermits live
I felt my mood
Narrow
Its walls thicken
Thoughts circling like birds over a landfill
So I tore off into the
Marathon Industrial Estate [_FORKLIFTS_]
A greek grove above its sign like one of Alice's headbands
I passed pagodas of skips, Chinese supermarket dragons
But still I was assailed, so I wandered into

UNKNOWN VOICE

Joel's Bargain Fabrix

THE NARRATOR

I strayed into its cotton gorges
Of chiffon and funeral lace, turning deeper and deeper
To evade my prevailing mood
A scabby kick-drum played from a speaker's parakeet
High in the dripping canopies
As I entered more and more remote hectares
Of the textiled mangrove, seeing few other souls
(A merchant in a yommaker, a girl
Comparing velvets) I crept
Into the centre of the fibrous forest
To where my heart's compass span idly
And all I heard were brooks of urinals
And rain sluicing off the warehouse's origami roof
I looked around and sure no one would see, or care
Leant back into 100% polyester
And for a few minutes
Slept. [_RAIN ON ROOF_]

XIII. Death

[_DRIPPING_]

THE NARRATOR

After the diamond deluge
Plane Street is birthmark'd with patches of wet
The archipelagoes of the sky
Developing in the puddles' negatives
Fronds of banana palms panting like Lizzie's tongue
As she leaps and skitters around
Catching the grassy comet of Peter's tennis ball

LIZZIE

Rrrrrrrrrrrrrrr-
Ruff!

THE NARRATOR

Presently, a maudlin fanfare of car horns sounds [_CAR HORNS_]
Detuned on the wet breeze
Bringing Dawn with Peter out front
The precinct clocktower announces 1 [_CLOCK CHIMING_]
And Plane Street falls silent
Goes into black and white
The funeral procession of Tony 1 rolls down its fossilised parade
The piranha'd fender of a hearse emerges on to the street
Absorbing the glances of onlookers into its sheen
The pavement populates
All eyes on the foaming reef of flowers in the boot
Where a fallen London patriarch lies in state

DAWN

Sensei, Dad, Legend

THE NARRATOR

At *Sensations* the workmen down tools
And doff their hardhats out of reverence
Fly-posters flick in windows cataracted with whitewash

UNKNOWN VOICE

Cinnamon Dock fireworks this Friday 20th of…
…Plane Street - where they make a desert they…

THE NARRATOR

Tony 2, in the car behind his father's coffin
Silent-filmed with hair gel

Waves to Dawn as they pass the *Queen of Wands*
The Victorian reenactment is completed [_FOOTSTEPS MARCHING_]
By the undertakers of *Morrisons Funerals*
In their penguin'd trousers and tailcoats
Faithful apart from their anachronistic headsets
Dawn watches the wind's shape in the rifling branches
Like arpeggios moving over piano strings
As the plane trees' hands applaud in a guard of honour high above
The funeral quartet passes underneath
The rusted maggots of dead pines sepia the scene
Into the Plane Street of the old photographs on the pub's walls
The horse-torn highway, the Wild West apothecary
The *Queen of Wands*' eternal temple stood on its swept corner
But who are the anachronisms of this scene?
The fragrant Chinese characters of the *Jade Inn*,
The spectres of new flats, basin-works, university dorms?
Or is it the procession itself
Marching out of time down the besieged high road
Peter and Lizzie, Captain *Sloe Gin* and hound
Romany Dawn with her rituals and charms
Her séances and table turnings
She turns another card now in her pocket

DAWN

'Strength'

LIZZIE *(growling)*

Rrrrrrr….rrrrrrrrr

THE NARRATOR

An olive-crowned priest comforts a flame-manged beast
Dawn looks at Peter, quieting Lizzie, gnarling her ball's bearded green.

XIV. Strength

[_DOG TRACK_]

THE NARRATOR

The attacking air was choked with ashtrays of leaves
From autumn's cull, shading the breath of the dogs
As they were led down the track, one pissed on the sleeve
Of its owner while wearing a Christmas tunic, up in the gods
This was noted by the punters as a lucky sign and

Bets flooded in for that Georgian brick-coloured dog
*Fly To Lisbon (*Lizzie for short) her white-grey lichen
Coat and furtive eyes gave fuel to their prayers
That she was a winner, hot-dogged kids were frightened
When sparks were shat out of that dirty robot hare
That electrocuted the pale iris-beach of the dog track [_RACE GUN_]

ANNOUNCER

And they're off!

THE NARRATOR

The gates flew open and the dogs gave chase, a rare
Syrup of concentration came over Lizzie, and out of the pack
Of accelerating hounds and flying sand, she emerged
In the lead, made a few furlongs and for one whole lap [_CROWD CHEERS_]
Stayed there: the punters screamed, her stock surged
Rising like aviation fuel in the windshield-scraper sky, Lizzie
Found another gear, but then in the second lap's final curve
With only the home straight to go, something grew busy
In her conical mind, some sense of hopelessness or defeat,
A weariness at the strait before her unending, with this she [_STEPS SLOWING_]
Inexplicably slowed and drifted to the far lane, the gluey seats [_SEATS SHUT_]
Clapped closed in disgust, programmes were thrown [_CROWD JEERING_]

PUNTER #1

Fly to Lisbon! Fuck off, I'll barely make back my bus fare

THE NARRATOR

Onto ammonia'd concrete with hotdog wrappers, no treats
For Lizzie, no victor's hot water bottle, instead her owners drove [_CARS_]
Out to the Great Road, to the *Marathon Industrial Estate*
And left her by a fabric warehouse's gates, in the cold autumn groves [_WIND_]
She waited for them to return, hungry and searching crates
Of discarded cherries, she began to wonder if at all
They'd come back, how she'd survive, she nosed the salt pan of the estate
Down the solemn stairs of a road bridge, through sour waterfalls [_DRIPPING_]
Of leak-water, Lizzie persevered, and bravely she shrugged
Off tarpaulin druids on that deafened cove, with their sleazy calls

BOAT DWELLER

What's the matter girlie, you lost?
Here girlie, here girlie - I got something for ya

THE NARRATOR

Then onto the canal, past brown and white loaves of Tudor pubs,
Golf courses with watery hills flagged like medieval paintings
She smelt the blue smoke of fishing fires, drank the suds
Of a barge's wake, used Cinammon Dock's star-towers' orientation
To surf an island of foamy rubbish, as she approached London's bruised lip
Where JCVs slept in ambered silos, light hammered on the basin's
Urn, there, Lizzie's pads were sore as the red hernia of sky ripped [_BIRDS_]
In the cloud's stomach lining, as she passed robot reefs and unpiloted bins
Her violin ribcage gave in to suffocating sleep, then she slipped [_WHEEZING_]
Into a ditch under the sadness of a prehistoric sky, trembling
Like the chicken pox skyline far downstream, but now a sympathetic
Engine, and splinter-proof hands soothing her, stepping off *Sloe Gin* [_MOTOR_]

PETER

Alright now, alright now, easy does it
Pete's got ya.

XV. The Heirophant

[_CROWD MILLING_]

THE NARRATOR

At the *Five Acres Crematorium*
A different kind of punter arrives
Shiny cat-faced aunts and bouncer colleagues
Clutching programmes like print-out parchments
Palimpsested with the face of Tony 1
Sandy-smiled, warm eyes amplified by thick lenses
A bolt of sun animates the hearse's jaguar
Glitters a grass bank in a playground
Just beyond the chapel
Where friends and relations mill around
In a sound-clash of aftershaves and perfumes
Old Plane Street accents

LYLE

Not seen Ton' yet
Hope he's alright

AISHA

Me too
Nervous for him

THE NARRATOR

At their feet a harlequin'd mulch of leaves
Stinking yellow and leathery purple
Eventually they are shown to their seats

TONY 2 *(into microphone)*

Ahem
Hello everyone

THE NARRATOR

Tony 2 stands up to the chapel lecturn
His nervy breath magnified on the microphone's filament

TONY 2

Thank you all for coming to *Five Acres* today to say goodbye to dad
I would just like to share a few life lessons that he taught me

THE NARRATOR

And as the younger Sensei speaks, an unusual restoration happens
Which Lyle, in the aisles, notices
Tony 2 polishes off and picks up the letters
That went missing in his Plane Street upbringing
He sands down the brutal *V* in the middle of

TONY 2

My father…

THE NARRATOR

He carefully places back the middle *T* axed out of

TONY 2

Taught us…

THE NARRATOR

He upgrades *money don't* into

TONY 2

Money doesn't…

THE NARRATOR

He reinstates the *H* missing from

TONY 2

Make you happy

THE NARRATOR

But through his remodelled accent,
Through the alcohol and ginseng rising up in the chapel
The old planes still poke through
Like the cheap wood beneath Peter's veneered boat-chest
Like the sweat patches under Tony's arms

TONY 2 *(finishing)*

A hateful heart is one that never knew love
And a black belt is a white belt that never gave up

THE NARRATOR

With that blunt jet, a contagion of tears starts up
First with Aisha, whose eyes brim like a swimming pool in a storm
Then infecting Lyle, who goes to comfort her
It's not the tears themselves
But her dignified resistance, her insistence
On covering them up, swallowing and recycling their basin water
That too infects him in their sweet momentum
A pensive Sinatra sings *Nancy With The Laughing Face* [_SINATRA PLAYS_]
As the conveyor belt offers up the coffin
Into a cage of hooded flames
In the chapel aisles, shaped like lungs
Plane Street exhales
The chimney sighs redolent smoke
Over the chapel's blast zone of graves
Over the canal's wrist towards Cinammon Dock
Drifting up to the Alpine headquarters at Virginia Yard beyond.

[_FLAMES FLICKER_]

XVI. The Tower

[_LAPTOP VIDEOS, RUSSIAN_]

THE NARRATOR

Where ice caps of cladding crested the unfinished [_BOLD LETTERS WHISPERED_]
Headquarters of a new bank building
On Cinammon Dock's malted shores, one night
Went Maxim, walking by the basin's gut, to
Intake some common minerals of London air, the thing he
Longed for most, and couldn't get up in his conditioned apartment
Longed for 12 floors up, the sole resident of Virginia Yard

MAXIM *(On videocall)*

Yes boss, work on the ice cream shop has begun
No boss, still waiting on the deeds to the kung fu place
Spasiba, it's just the pub that remains

THE NARRATOR

Closing the call, Maxim went down to Cinammon Dock's
Lamenting parade, the Moscow emigre, fixer, love agent
Everything he did cashless, clueless and rootless
An estranged soldier stationed in a gleaming investment
Next to one of London's pickled precincts
Yellowed by fridges he went into the ice cave of

MAXIM

Millenium Stores

THE NARRATOR

Old walls of chiselled cereal boxes and [_SHOP SCANNING_]
Undulations of late night noodles
Reluctantly he chose a ramen and paid
Feigning urgency, he hurried back down the chilling cobbles
Lolloping away from the jangles of pub jeers [_DISTANT PUB_]
A plane tree had collapsed down drunk into the basin's
Toilet, he was afraid, for despite the signs of life in the
Porthole flats, where lived other global agents like him, those
Of Tokyo, of Johannesburg, Aman City, there still was the old
Unsettling candlesticks of Bengali street signs, the rot of rivers to
Remind him that these towers were not just polygons, so
Yearning for the pub, to be among the jeers, he followed their clang,
Only Agent Maxim could not be seen there, so
Under lollipops of slurred light he returned to his tower's
Rendered mangroves and tearful gates, which
Delivered him into the blood-warm lobby
Rose him out of the fronded atrium
Into the wrap-fresh lift
Noodles in his ridiculous bag, his first solo supper in London [_LIFT GOES UP_]
Knots of noodles undoing in hot water, now [_BOILING WATER_]
Web-surfing for Russian movies accompanied his bachelor's dinner

MAXIM

Cossack warriors triumph the in battle against Napoleon!

THE NARRATOR

How Maxim yearned for the pub's explosions, he looked out,

Etched on his penthouse vista were
Nameless bird-islands in the basin
Yachts of hope twisting against the meridian, an
Orange sky forested with dark rain and
Under it, the twinkling peninsula of Cinammon Dock, his temporary home
Volcanoes of old towers block erupting, like
Emails flooding in from Moscow on Maxim's desktop reef

LAPTOP ALERT
Kагент Максим - INTRUDER ALERT [_ALARMS_]

THE NARRATOR
In the unfinished gym Maxim checked his multi-cam display
Like an excavated Roman bath, his monitors snorkelled,
Light skewering the labyrinth of breeze-blocks, he saw only textiles on his
Esoteric CCTV screens, then he glimpsed a ghost running through
Droning glades of fountains in the plaza – he sprinted downstairs [_RUNNING_]
Urgently to catch the vandal but found just a spray-painted hex on the
Site of a disturbed soul

UNKNOWN WOMAN'S VOICE
Who will clean your flat pour your drink when you've killed us
Where they make a desert, they call it peace

XVII. Ten of Pentacles

[_DESOLATE WIND_]

THE NARRATOR
Smudging ash off his black sleeve
Tony 2 smokes outside the *Five Acres Crematorium*
After the ceremony under a dirty yellow sky
He is greeted by a retinue of his own ghosts
Great aunts [_GREETINGS_]

TONY 2
Hello Linda
Norma, Maureen

THE NARRATOR
And uncles

TONY 2

Alright Len,
Johnny, Frank

THE NARRATOR

They overwhelm him with their scented condolences
So he peels off into the blast zone of graves, watching monk-like crows
Bow in the slingshot trees, flinching in the basin's nuclear wind
A sea-bed of fox-fur grass
Slobbers on his black shoes, patenting the leather
As he wanders through generations of tooth-graves [_PACING, WET GRASS_]
First, the rotten milk-teeth of Victorians

TONY 2

Ada, Ethel, Bronwen

THE NARRATOR

Sunken into mossy gums, cracked and plaqued
Held up by braces of scaffolds, he beholds them
Next, he walks through the molars of Plane Street's Jews

TONY 2

Herschel, Solomons, Jacobs

THE NARRATOR

Squat tombs glittering with silver fillings of stones
Etched with tens of pentacles, Stars of David
Tony skirts them, like Hebrew, from right to left
Past the wisdom teeth of grand industrialist family plinths
Deep-sunken stones housing factory dynasties

TONY 2

Shaw, Robertson, Demaunay

THE NARRATOR

Foremen to his ancestors
Then finally he arrives on the fresh gummy mound
Where the newest graves lie
Modern veneers like lasered marble in the Virginia Yard
Housing an atlas of newcomers

TONY 2

Iraqi, Cypriot, Irish-Jamaican

THE NARRATOR
From that sweetened mound Tony watches
Grainy rain soften a horizon
Jagged with towers
Blue whales of financial headquarters
The grinding teeth of unseen roads behind them
He tastes air cut with citrus
Lyle and Aisha join him at the summit

LYLE
How you getting on?

TONY 2
Yeah, alright, just needed a minute

AISHA *(Shivering)*
Anything we can do, just let us know

TONY 2
Thanks, I will do. You both look smart

LYLE
Only best for your dad Ton
Speech was tremendous by the way, had us in bits

THE NARRATOR
The trauma of late the afternoon sky recovers in creases of light [_BIRDS_]
The fading cell of the sun foils the fjords
Around the buildings at Cinammon Dock
Piercing a thunderhead
Skyscrapers are arranged like Aisha's makeup set in the chapel toilets
A lipstick tower, a high-rise eyeliner
Light drains off udders of chimneys in Plane Street's backwaters
Shines through a train's celluloid [_TUBE TRAIN_]
Screening the trees in a flip-book of seasons
Aisha prepares for her greatest performance yet.

XVIII. The Star

[_TUBE, MUSIC_]

AISHA *(singing)*
If I don't see her each day I miss her
Gee, what a thrill each time I kiss her

THE NARRATOR

Making her connection, just
Aisha stepped off the Cinammon Dock monorail
Onto the platform at Plane Street's changeover
Snowed on by evening lamps
A raft of metal captured by nettles
And rude cadavers of lavender

AISHA *(singing to headphones)*

She takes the winter and makes it summer
Summer could take some lessons from her

THE NARRATOR

From overground to underground she went
Following the sorrel wind, descending the escalator
Like steps into the core of a pyramid
The peppery-museum smell of exhaust and perished rubber
Sliding down the tube's grimy hieroglyphs

AISHA

Believe me I've got a case
On Nancy…with the laughin' face

THE NARRATOR

A ball of wind was projected down the platform
Turbulence scattering mice and eviscerating newspapers
Scattering like Aisha's nerves, as she sang lowly to herself
She boarded the Central-bound tube, setting her handsome skirt
On the primordial blue fur of the seats
Fixing her make-up in her reflection, Siamese'd in the curved windows
Where electric eels of other trains flashed and vanished
She listened to the bearded wartime announcements

ANNOUNCEMENT

This is…Cinnamon Dock
Alight here for…Virginia Yard
This train is for…Lyme Circus
Mind the gap please
Mind the gap

THE NARRATOR

Aisha emerged into the Central London night [_HEELS, CENTRAL LONDON_]
Javelins of Lyme Circus pounded around here
Pub-mountains frosted with ivy and smudged lamps
Yeasty laughs of City Boys rang off pint-skittled corners

Where her professional heels thudded the lava-dripped streets

CITY BOY #1

Oi oi love
Black don't crack, ain't that right?

THE NARRATOR

She found the coffee'd lane
Whose upper floors held a buttery intrigue
And out of the ammonia rock-pools of piss alleys, found the office

AISHA

4th Floor – London Cruise Talent

THE NARRATOR

She rang the vile buzzer [_OFFICE BUZZER_]

AISHA *(finishing practice)*

Have you ever heard mission bells ringin'?
Well, she'll give you the very same glow…that's *Nancy*

THE NARRATOR

Now time for Aisha's destiny
Someone had heard her sing open mic at a
Bruised cruise-side karaoke in Cinammon Dock

ANNOUNCER

Aisha T, London's soul diva, singing live tonight!

THE NARRATOR

Then they had invited her to sing in Town one even
Now she felt the potential of Central night fizzing in her veins
The stardom of its sounds, like the tubes running under her feet

AISHA *(singing out loud)*

When she speaks you would think it was singin'
Just hear her say "hello"

THE NARRATOR

In that hairy-felted office, she sang *Nancy* by Sinatra
Her Standard, her showstopper
An agent and two sidekicks listened and conferred

TALENT SCOUT

Thank very much for coming in love

We'll be in touch

THE NARRATOR
And so she returned, the Star of Cinammon Dock
Back to her balconied perch
(They never were).

[_CENTRAL AMBIENCE DIES OUT_]

XIX. The Hanged Man

[_ PUB, BUSY_]

THE NARRATOR
As afternoon thickens into evening
The ceiling of the Queen of Wands
Bubbles like a crimson wax seal
The red-roof of its mouth tiger'd by candle lights
Dawn is in the safe room, resetting her hair
With laser-hot curlers
Its flinty highlights of blonde and black like sunflowers
She poofs the shoulder pads of her sherbet pink jacket
Reshuffles her paisley scarf like the tarot

DAWN
'The Hanged Man'

The wake has begun, and the tribe has returned
Tearing into the feast
Of sacrificial scotch eggs, garlands of pineapples
A supermarket Samhain
Cellophaned festival of the dead

TONY 2
Tasty, these
Where'd you get them Dawn?

DAWN
Tony 2 with his slapped eyes could be a silent film urchin
In his loosened black tie and shirt sleeves
Still badgered by relatives
His sister-in-law
A straw-blonde mum who grew up on the English coast

(Not Plane Street)
Her gothic kids crawling under the spread table
Tying shoelaces together mischievously
Unknowingly they goad Lyle and Aisha
Gomes and Morticia, back on the Guinness and vodka
Childless and knowing that barge of opportunity has fled

AISHA

Cheeky things

LYLE

Yeah, good job we never…

NARRATOR

The kids know to steer clear of Peter
Lizzie growling at his legs
And beyond the funeral party's cordon
A few tourists
And a Russian Roman, drinking a pint like no one has ever drunk one
Waiting for instructions from Moscow on an intruder
Harpooning iridescent fish on his phone [_ PHONE GAMES_]

MAXIM *(playing)*

Come on, come on
High score…*Niet!*

NARRATOR

He calms his nerves in the game-reefs of *Hula Island*
But secretly he earwigs on the wake's warmth, borrowing its vibe
Like a spider snuck indoors
Knowing he would be a hanged man if caught
For his lonely espionage in enemy territory

LYLE

So the Ruskie money's coming in then?

TONY 2

Yeah not long now
They're alright really
Gave me a good price

LYLE

Saw they've started on the ice cream place
Romans buying everything up now
Not your fault - of course Ton

TONY 2

No, exactly
Nobody's fault really

THE NARRATOR

Presently, out of a mirrorball's zodiac, Aisha flips on the karaoke mixer
And the chattering wake falls quiet [_ MIC FEEDBACK_]
After an intro of warm brothy, captive strings [_ SINATRA_]
She begins to sing

AISHA *(Singing)*

If I don't see her each day, I miss her
Oh gee what a thrill to kiss her
It seems that I've got a case
Of *Nancy*

THE NARRATOR

Her bruised contralto stains the air, with all its unmatched potential
As car lights soak through the papery pub windows
Her voice drifts out and over the bridges of the basin
Peter slips outside into the flaking Autumn night

TONY 2

Miserable bastard

LYLE

Yeah, what's into him?

THE NARRATOR

Foggy vocals brighten the scene
Dawn, given a breather, returns to her cards

DAWN

Now let's see…
'The Emperor'

THE NARRATOR

An opulent boy watches from his stony seat
From the canal's amphitheatre, I peep into the wake through a
Porthole drawn to the London sirens.

[_KARAOKE STARTS_]

XX. The Emperor

[_TRAFFIC_]

THE NARRATOR

Under a varicose evening sky I walked at rush hour
Among queued headlights and the holy smell of petrol
Assailed again by misery
I peeled off into backstreets
Where upright dragonflies of telephone masts winged the sky
If only their wires could be traced like family lines
From the freckled houses in this slum of origins
To a place on the fire-threaded horizon, London's lip
That's from where I would trace my own lines
Back to Plane Street, where they disappear into [_LEAVES RUSTLING_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

A plane tree's
Dynasty of twigs, its brain
Of synapse-leaves shivering
A lamp x-raying its green bones
He stand underneath and tastes the
Charcoal'd leaves,
Photosynthesising Memories
Into its
Bitter
Trunk
A cold elephant's
Foot flaked
With mud, khaki'd
By shade, stood on buckled
Pavement, like him fissured
By roots but also made

THE NARRATOR

In *Varmint's Pie & Mash* [_PIE AND MASH SHOP_]
The lady poured liquor thinly onto my plate
Green as algae in the curdled basin
With spoon and fork I slid into
The empty booth like a church aisle
And split the sauce with spiky vinegar
Like speech bubbles of brown oil in the canal
In that tiled temple, where once I had taken Alice of all people
Before she became a terrorist
And she uttered so many blasphemies

ALICE *(disgusted)*

It's like school dinners

THE NARRATOR

Now I communed with my ancestor-gods
Appealing for morsels of authenticity
Among the dwindling parish of cockney myths
In that toothy chamber
They seemed to manifest on my plate
Like a gravy clairvoyance
Starchy clouds of mash like industrial steam
From workhouses, the face of some hatted relative in tea leaves
The embossed crust of pies like cobbled curbs
Dishwater detritus poured into drains
Chilis embalmed in sunset vinegar

CASHIER

Closing up now love
You want to take that away?

THE NARRATOR

Two pies full and night now slashing around me
I began to feel London's dark peons appealing
Tugged by aquatic living rooms
I felt the spear-fall of dignity and
Truth in quiet-shelled closes
Then heard a siren-voice drifting across the crude oil canals [_SOFT SINGING_]
A wake in the *Queens of Wands*, I sought it out

AISHA *(singing)*

Have you ever heard mission bells ringin'?
Well, she'll give you the very same glow…that's *Nancy*

THE NARRATOR

And as I peeped through its bloodshot portholes
I was tense with conditionals watching the scene inside
In that basin pub that, if it wasn't for right-to-buys
And my family's pruned garden of dreams, would've been my local
The breathy beer-smell and coiny laughter chided me [_WATER, PUB JEERS_]
As I voyeur'd the simmering wake
The easy chat of the noble lads multicoloured
Who would've been my schoolmates
I mourned the want to belong inside, the indestructible urge

To be out of the purple minted mud
And plump birdsong of the canal, the glacial streets
And be among Saturday night TV warmth
The wallpaper like blonde highlights Of the girls I would've loved

ALICE

Where they make a desert, they call it peace

THE NARRATOR

But I had loved Alice in another London
Presently, I felt familiar a nexus
Impossible tangles of sex, envy, inferiority tugged
Now, like a warm spirit of water in the cold basin
I felt a ghost levitating – not Tony 1's
But that of his modest son, roughly the same age as me, who I watched
Holding court, a humble emperor
In black tie and shirtsleeves
Me, an affluent pauper watching on
He galled me with the depth of his wires
Goaded me with his trueness of his roots,
I noticed the desolate shops either side of the pub
And above an auspicious star seemed to gleam.

[_SINGING SUBSIDES TO WATER LAPPING, THEN SILENCE_]

Part Three:
Christians

Prologue

[_ELECTRICAL SIGNALS_]

UNKNOWN VOICE

And so God created mankind in his own image
In the image of God he created them
Male and female he created them
God blessed them and said to them
Be fruitful and increase in number, fill the earth and subdue it
Rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky
And over every living creature that moves on the ground.

XXI. Ten of Cups

[_ROAD WORKS_]

THE NARRATOR

A road crew pours almond light out of an electrical fault
As the sleepers of Plane Street and Cinammon Dock
Are renewed by dreams
Intervals of night
Like the gaps between the fishing line of planes [_RUNWAY _]
Queuing for runway space from the long-haul uplands
Their broadening quills of trails under the bulleted moon

LAPTOP SERMON SPEAKING

The apostle Paul writes
'Therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God
I urge you to present your bodies as a living sacrifice
Holy and pleasing to God - this is your spiritual worship'

THE NARRATOR

In the low streets fists of muscular Spanish wind squall [_WIND, LEAVES _]
Dragging the crab-shells of dead plane leaves
Over paving slabs dipped in syrup
A nest of laptops twitches in the new towers
Clacks of a fireworks bandstand going up can be heard [_METAL GIRDERS _]
A curtained fug hums
From the *Queen of Wands*, where a lock-in of legends has begun

DAWN

Aisha, would you be a darling
Draw those blinds, will you?

THE NARRATOR

Queen Dawn
And her roundtable of unlikely knights, form a ten of cups
Peter, a ponytailed Merlin
Lyle and Aisha, Lancelot and Guinevere
Tony 2, with his helmet-flattened hair
A crusader weighed down by swords and treasure
Somehow Maxim, a guest from a distant realm
Is granted stay in this sealed court
Of tarantula drapes and cockney candles, beer-branded heraldry
Dawn sits at the head of the table
Her helmet-beehive freshly soldered
By her beloved curlers in the safe-room

DAWN *(whispering)*

Excaliburs…

THE NARRATOR

Outside water is sieved through a bloody lane
Foxes sing in condemned meadows, eyes coined by passing cars
The jasmine smell in the garden flower-boxes is enlarged
Redolent, crazy
Rude as the contrast of the infrared streets
A cotton-lit tailback clots on the Great Road

RADIO ANNOUNCER

Sugar lorry jackknife…
Queues all the way to Hilltop

THE NARRATOR

Incants the radio, but Dawn already knows
Her crystals told her, she stands up

DAWN

Right, now everyone's got a drink
Let's begin

THE NARRATOR

Maxim the Muscovite slips out, sensing an unmasking, a truth-session
He drains his unaccounted pint, returns to his tower
Now the elders link hands in a pocketful of posies
A flower-chain extending from Dawn to Peter to Aisha to Lyle to...
Reluctant, sceptical Tony 2
But he is willed on by Lyle, smiling with silver fangs like parrot-heads
To complete the circle

DAWN

Now before we start the séance
I ask you all to please turn your phones off

[_ELECTRICAL SIGNALS DIE OFF _]

THE NARRATOR

Electrical disturbances are snuffed out
A wave of nettles bows, the road crew restores the grid
A princess turns over in her cold foundation-bed
Wind recedes over the bladdered sector
Guinness upsets the water table, sieved through a million drains
Plants in leisure-centre forecourts tilt, waxed with the moon's gel
Dawn turns over her card, they look on

LYLE *(reading)*

'The Magician'

THE NARRATOR

A haloed conjuror begins a miracle, a grail set on her ivy table
He looks up at Dawn, her smoking hairdo Saturn'd by lamps.

XXII. The Magician

[_PARTS TINKERING_]

THE NARRATOR

Strewn with mosaics
Of computer parts, Aztec
Circuitboards and reliefs
Lyle watched from

LYLE

Omega Computers

THE NARRATOR

Where he worked, a plane tree's winter brain chipped
Implanted, a nest

LYLE

January 1993… [_DOJO, JUDO PRACTICE_]

THE NARRATOR

It was when he
And Tony 1's team

Had reached the finals
In national group
Judo, Tony 2 just born
And the Dojo then
The heart of a renaissance
Of martial arts, where
Estates stood apart
Like karate kids posing
On matts of grass

TONY 1 *(alive)*

Today lads, we represent our estate: Nancy House, Plane Street

THE NARRATOR

Stretchers fencing off
Courts named for princesses
Where mint sauce smells wandered
Accompanied by lovers rock tunes
They appeared on local news
Making the semis
When Lyle, grabbing
The gown of a Hull sensei
Overexerted [_THROWN OVER _]

LYLE

Masutemi…
Waza!

THE NARRATOR

And popped his shoulder
(An achilles in Judo terminology)
So they contacted
Dawn, governess, faith-healer
At the *Queen of Wands*

TONY 1

I just hope to God you can help him

DAWN

I'll do better than *god*
I'll speak with the ancients

THE NARRATOR

She laid Lyle down on [_JEWELLERY RATTLING_]
Her witchdoctor's altar, the bar
Performed reiki over

The stricken shoulder
A miracle of Plane Street
Was granted, Lyle's
Sprain-flame extinguished

LYLE *(incredulous)*

That's unbelievable
Good as new

THE NARRATOR

And in the final they soundly
Beat Hilltop rivals
Now years later Judo shrivelled from Lyle's Life, for computers
Except for passwords
Where it crouched, like a crystallised dream
As he rebooted:

LYLE

Nancy93.

XXIII. The World

[_WATER, MURMURING_]

THE NARRATOR

Twin sisters Cinammon Dock and Plane Street stand
A skipping rope of canal spooled between them
One made-over with her lipstick towers, her eye-shadow parks
Her lashes of palms mascara'd with shadow
Her sequinned dramas and bracelets of trains
The other a dirty-faced unloved canyon

[_HELICOPTER_]

HELICOPTER INTERCOM

Just coming over the old canal now…
Yep, see the basin

THE NARRATOR

From a helicopter, blending up the carbonated sky with its oars
Can be seen a golden triangle
Between the heights and the slums
An unintended landscape of aching
Corporate forecourts exfoliated by gritted rain
Marine light from conference hotels moisturised for no one

Gabled flats and belted quays knocking in the breeze [_KNOCKING_]
Closed up dry cleaners frowning, a bitter wind
Broadcast over the hatched water all the way to the red-lipped shore
Of one vast unmanned continent, moustachioed with hairy grass
The exclusion zone of Plane Street
Like an unexploded bomb-meadow
There, the messages of the spirit-kingdom
London Minor are now channelled
As Dawn begins her séance
A Medusa curled with sunflower-highlights of blonde and black
Burnt by her *Excalibur* irons:

DAWN

We are here to speak beyond the veil
I call on the spirit circle to communicate with us

THE NARRATOR

She intones in vintage Plane Street, the clairvoyance of
Costermongers and hair-salon oracles
The green scent of sage
Burning on the bar tops, mingling with the blunt funk of the banquet spread
Dawn slides a photograph of Tony 1 into the middle of the table

DAWN

We wish to speak with our friend Tony

THE NARRATOR

The storm of her breath rolls and spasms like the leaves [_CHOPPER, STORMS_]
Outside the pub
She lays her deck of intuition around the photo
Each card a story in the table's stone circle

DAWN

'The Star'…

THE NARRATOR

Aisha and her moonlit voice carried on Cinammon Dock's shoals

DAWN

'The Lovers'…

THE NARRATOR

Her and Lyle gripping hands tightly in a masque'd dance

DAWN

'The Fool'…

THE NARRATOR

Peter in his basin of silence, awaiting viking burial on *Sloe Gin*

DAWN

'The Tower'…

THE NARRATOR

Maxim and his newfangled citadel, harried by tridents of pub jeers

DAWN

'The Empress'…

THE NARRATOR

Alice, the graffiti activist, ghostly disruptor, moving across the
Membrane of CCTV dimensions
Like that buried princess
Somewhere, Dawn feels her presence
In the holy wells of
Fruit machines concussing
Menageries of doom
Aquamarine, new moons, sage-embers, fox feet
Radio seas scrambling
[_HELICOPTER INTENSIFIES_]

DAWN

I feel the presence of someone familiar
Are you ready Tony?

THE NARRATOR

He nods, the helicopter banks low in its search
Visiting the world like a bee
Its humming rattles the séance glasses [_GLASSES SHAKING_]
It's cabin a lantern'd ship far out to sea
Dawn's blind eyes flicker like flyers in the window of *Sensations*

ALICE

To rule over the earth and subdue it
The fish in the sea and the birds in the sky
Where they make a desert they call it peace!

THE NARRATOR

The photograph migrates, an avatar wobbling in the chopper-quake
The helicopter to seems to whisk clouds into a portal [_SHAKING INTENSIFIES_]

DAWN

Sensei, are you with us?
Let it be known if so

THE NARRATOR

Tony 2 with one eye open watches a card shaken to the floor
A rebel queen, sat in a marijuana'd court

TONY 2 (*reading)*

'The Empress'.

[_HELICOPTER DIES OUT_]

XXIV. The Empress

[_JOINT BEING ROLLED, TYPING_]

THE NARRATOR

It was midnight in Hilltop
Where amphibious streets squeaked, and a helicopter reaped
Across the fennel seed-impregnated houses
Alice lay in her mountainous bed
Typing her latest tirade

ALICE

Save Plane Street from Romans Developers
Oppose their mission in our communities
When they talk, London listens

THE NARRATOR

She typed her takedown of the new Romans to London's dell
From her bohemian boudoir
Her red deltas of hair and silver nose stud
Lending her the appearance of a Celtic noblewoman

ALICE

Protest tomorrow at the precinct
Where they make a desert, they call it peace

THE NARRATOR

Alice posted and sparked up the zoot
She opened her attic window on a coastal London wind
Looked out across the zone

Tall books condescended from shelves in darkened houses
Behind windows that would dampen a piano's thuds
Message from Jennifer [_PHONE NOTIFICATION_]

JENNIFER

Hey, did you eat my pasta?

ALICE

Yeah
And what?

JENNIFER

Well
Were you going to cook some more?

ALICE

No, I'm smoking

JENNIFER

My weed, you mean?

ALICE

Well, that's hypocritical
You and Mark ate mine when you were smoking last week

THE NARRATOR

The fourth argument in as many days
Alice turned over her phone like a tarot card
She had more important causes than another
Drama from Jennifer
The woman who was downstairs
And her mother
She finished the zoot and closed the window
Laid back into a hydroponic duck feather cloud [_SILENCE_]
The next morning, she stood on the dirty jawed porch of their house [_BIRDS_]
Unchaining her bike
She smelt the flaky paint, prized up by the marigold day
Jennifer again [_PHONE NOTIFICATION_]

JENNIFER

Hey - I'm sorry about last night
It was just a super stressful day
At work and I wanted to get high

ALICE

Hey, it's ok
I'm sorry too

JENNIFER

Good luck with the protest today
Sorry can't make it
I'll see you for Nick's tonight

THE NARRATOR

And putting away her phone
Alice cycled off down the curved hill street [_BIKE WHEELS_]
The clean air pearling the silver of her nose stud
She listened to a podcast as she went

PODCASTER

Mission colonialism is a type of colonialism in which
Missionaries move to and permanently reside on land
Already inhabited by indigenous residents

THE NARRATOR

As she descended from those artistic altitudes
Bricks darkened on the houses
Pampas in the front gardens grew scruffier
Pavements twisted up like bad teeth
She cycled into the alleyway that led from Hilltop to Hillbottom
Where she sometimes said she was from
The weak mid afternoon sun, sliced up by slats of railway fence
Strobed her face as she went
Straining out her freckles
Paprika stars on a white sea

ALICE *(megaphone)*

Save Plane Street from Romans Developers [_BUSY STREET_]
Oppose mission colonisation in our communities
When they talk, London listens
Where they make a desert…

THE NARRATOR

Alice stood on the aboriginal cobbles of Plane Street's highway
She wore her seasoned all-weather protest gear
The coat once worn by her father, Nicholas
Among the shoppers she spotted a few red blazers

ALICE *(to kids)*

Hey! Hillbottom High
That was my school

THE NARRATOR

The pupils from her alma mater didn't hear her
They walked through her protest, as if she was immaterial
Message from Jennifer

[_PHONE NOTIFICATION_]

JENNIFER

How's it going?
Can you pick up some plantains for dinner
Back at 6

THE NARRATOR

Alice packed up her picket and began her ascent back to Hilltop
As she skirted the foot of the London mountain [_BIKE WHEELS_]
She noticed another famous uniform from her teen-hood
The affluent gold purple of Whittingham Park School
Absorbing more of her scorn
She hiked on her pedals back up the nettle-reefed galley
That lead to her house
Hillbottom High kids now swarmed around her [_SCHOOL KIDS_]
In a queasy centrifuge of accents and classes
Their red blazers clotted like blood cells at the cut of the alley

HILLBOTTOM KID 1

She's just some posh girl from Hilltop trying to be street

HILLBOTTOM KID 2

I know - have you seen her house?

THE NARRATOR

Briefly Alice had felt heartened
Connected to this London artery
But as she ascended she noticed the centrifuge doing its work
As the heavier particles, the darker faces
The harsher accents sank down to the dell
While she, and her equivalents,
Clear-skinned, clear-thinking, clear-voiced
Rose effortlessly to the peak, like white cells

[_NIGHT SOUNDS_]

[_PHONE NOTIFICATION_]

JENNIFER
Hey, you ok? You seemed a little quiet at dinner

ALICE
Hey, yeah, I'm fine
Just thinking about Nick

THE NARRATOR
Back in her room, Alice held her cherished cork-board
On which she pinned her vital things
Festival pictures with school-mates
Flyers from previous protests
A quote she had heard and liked

ALICE
And so they remake London in their image

THE NARRATOR
And a picture of Nicholas
She unpinned it and opened the sweaty window to smoke [_LIGHTER, WIND_]
The night played its arias in the planes
He was handsome, she thought
Not unlike her type
And Alice the Empress drank all of London from the Hilltop
It's prehistoric estates
It's blinking black star-fields
Its hills and dells.

XXV. Knight of Wands

[_CREAKING SIGN_]

THE NARRATOR
Wind maracas the streaked pub sign at the *Queen of Wands*
In a séance moving across its amphitheatre
Thumb-printed with yellow leaves from half-looted trees
Like fans twirling yellow scarves on gnarled terraces
The blazing birches are matador'd by a storm's currents
Devil-lights of helicopter landing pads are horns
On the misted mountain of Virginia Yard, graffiti scrubbed off
They are flung like livid pods
Steaming into the basin's hatched foundry

Meanwhile unearthly light plays at the edges of the pub curtains
As its wax ceiling simmers and treacles

DAWN *[Shut eyes flickering]*
Tony, your father is speaking with me now
Do you have a message for him?

TONY 2
OK…Dad…it's me, love you, miss you
I found this today

THE NARRATOR
He slides his child's armoury of sword-drawings over the table
A cave-painting chiseled out of the dojo tomb
Crayon-slicks glaring under the hot lights

DAWN *[hand on crystals]*
Your father is glad of the offering
He wants you to know he's very proud
He will see you in the next world
Whenever that may be

THE NARRATOR
The others in the circle watch on
Lizzie covers her eyes with her paws, Peter calms her under the table
In the safe-room the wind shakes a cloth in the ancient chimney's throat
Wheezing soot over Dawn's shrine of crystals
The tarot books and bags of gold
Her library of the ancients
Like swords in a stone
Her *Excalibur* curlers plugged into their charger port
Just catch the night-sky velvet blanket
As the storm breathes and Dawn mediates with the dead
The curlers cook that magician's cloak into magma [_FLAMES FLICKER_]
A volcano slope glowing in its creases, sliding like a black glacier
Towards the back bar and saloon

LYLE
Ton, it's me Lyle
Been thinking about the dojo days today
Good memories mate

THE NARRATOR

While Lyle speaks the flame snags, moans at a plunge-pool of drapes
A reverse-waterfall of fire streams up to the boiling ceiling
Aisha is roused from the trance by the smell of sulphur

AISHA *(shouting)*

Dawn…Fire!

THE NARRATOR

The priestess bolts up, demolishing crystals with the sweep of a chained hand
Like a wrecking ball knocking down a fossilised parade [_CRYSTALS SMASH_]
Her cards flurry in the gesture
Like a paisley bird obliterated
Already flames cage the bar's wooden altar, like the Sensei's coffin
A frame of sparkling wicker
Tony and Aisha chuck jugs of holy water onto the fire
While Lyle unbarricades the locked-in door

AISHA *(shouting)*

Wait…Peter!

THE NARRATOR

Standing up, a silent viking
Peter strides into Valhalla's burning city
In an act self-immolation among hellfires
His comic waders now forming fire-armour, Lizzie a Cerberus [_BOTTLES BURST_]
Cocktail'd fireworks of brandy, Tia Maria and vodka burst around him
Old photographs of Plane Street curl and shrink
A smouldering card curves on the abandoned table

DAWN

'The Devil'…

THE NARRATOR

A bull-horned ogre floats in the sky
Chained where he is, by woman.

XXVI. The Devil

[_FIREWORKS_]

THE NARRATOR

A spark-shower
Like the prairies of her hair brushing over my shoulder
As a duet of rockets went up

Dispersing saffron over Cinnamon Dock

ALICE

Looks like a cross
Or a trident

THE NARRATOR

Alice and I had met for last orders in *Varmint's Pie & Mash* [_CUTLERY, SHOP_]
She, mortified by its vibeless tomb
Me, trying to lecture her on the place that she was from
The place I was so faintly related to

ALICE

If your family is from Plane Street
Why did you go to Whittingham Park?

THE NARRATOR

Afterwards, tipsy lights of cars rounded the common's edge [_MORE FIREWORKS_]
Where martian palms shivered
In itchy wind, smells of rain soured the path
And now the fireworks spiced Alice's hair
Like the carbon locked-up in the planes

ALICE

Hey, I recognise those girls
From my year at Hillbottom

THE NARRATOR

I had always wanted to rise like balloon into it, lean into its kindling
I watched her eyes televise the display

ALICE

Toxic green orchard

THE NARRATOR

Tinkling pheromonal flamingo

ALICE

Sighing dandelions

THE NARRATOR

Finger pink gravel, being poured down our necks
Behind the wobbling plane-brain
We were taken by aphrodisiac dead-tree smells, kissed there

ALICE

I never usually kiss boys like you

THE NARRATOR

The breath-steam clouded the sphere of her nose-stud
The cold applied itself to her cheeks
In a permafrost of lager and saxophone mist
We escaped to the nearest pub garden
To engage in mutual destruction
Duelling identities
In that courtyard of smoky memory

ALICE

People say Hilltop is posh
But when Nick and Jennifer bought the house
It was like…

THE NARRATOR

Nothing - frozen out, we went inside in overcooked coats
Found a warm mouse-hole under lymphatic fairy lights
Then at the night's end we stood nearly-close
Her eyes skated with those common-rounding cars
Time-lapsed headlights stretched out into tubes
I smelt her burning scarf
As we created pond-cold kisses
Chiming like buses on her cheek-skin

ALICE

This place…
I went to school with the owners' daughter

THE NARRATOR

Alice announced by *Nancy's* [_CHINESE CHIP SHOP_]
And a shell of envy ripped through me like a firework
As we passed under the fragrant neon characters of its signage
Grease sullen lanterns bobbed like tethered fireworks inside
The back chain-door gossiped with woks
A fatty batter smell pervaded
As Alice opened the copious baskets of her school years

ALICE

She went out with the biggest gangster in Hillbottom
One of Plane Street Gang
Everyone knew he was wrong 'un
He was in a car crash last year

THE NARRATOR

She goaded me with her ginseng sagas
The sexy nights on the common's dark dew, soul-assailing arrows
I felt a hangar in my throat, for all the lost time of London
The gas-blue star-fields, the barbecued scenery
The trees like wet lettuce
I saw high up, a plane dragged across the sky like an anchor
Stirring up the floor of a muddy basin
Would my silted heart ever settle

ALICE

So
We're going back to mine yeah?
Jennifer's in, hopefully you won't have to meet her

THE NARRATOR

Who was Jennifer? Nicholas? [_CAR DOORS, ENGINE_]
Javelins of rain slipped down the cab windows as we got in
And the driver's radio corals played a jasmine fugue [_LIGHT RADIO_]
Interrupted by whispered phone-calls
Alice and I watched in our separate cinemas
Two very different films
Hers, a fantasy of life almost-lived
Mine, a tragedy a plane tree uprooted
Apparitions of smoke spiders haunted off the Great Road
After fireworks
Wipers smeared colourless rainbows across the windscreen's breadth
I felt something clotting in a place I couldn't reach
Like the zone of tears beyond the wipers' arms

ALICE *(to driver)*

Just on the right please, thanks so much

THE NARRATOR

We arrived on the salamander street
Of her bohemian pile
Alice led the way, taking my hand in furry darkness to the kitchen [_MICROWAVE_]
She opened the buxom fridge and found an open bottle of Prosecco, echo-
Location like a dolphin's pips sounded as popcorn microwaved, waved
Me towards the flat's grand dimensions, mentioned
That for all her local heroism, she was an alien on Plane Street just like me

ALICE *(whispering)*

Shhhh - remember she's sleeping

THE NARRATOR

We went up the armpit-funked floorboards
Into the new age hollow of her bedroom
Into the sandalwood boudoir
A Golden Chinese cat waving
A financial district of crystals storming out of its flowing window

ALICE

Can you hold this? I'm gonna roll

THE NARRATOR

As I held the long-skin
I inspected the room like a caver
Apostle-photos of school-friends, sermons of deserts and peace
Revolutionary tomes like dead sea scrolls
I made some crack about hippies calling their parents by the first names

ALICE

Well at least you still have both

THE NARRATOR

She turned away from me to blow smoke
Now I saw saintly photo of Nicholas on the cork-board
Crucified there with drawing pins
The dead man with affluent cheeks,
Not unlike me.

XXVII. Judgement

[_FIRE CRACKLING_]

THE NARRATOR

Now a cone of sparks
Juts into the screaming fog
Above the *Queen of Wands*
A volcano to rival the towers of Cinammon Dock
Sparks rise like tainted snowflakes recalled to heaven
A black shoe thrown through a window bursts onto the forecourt [_GLASS SMASH_]
Diamonding its asphalt

TONY 2 *(calling from inside)*

We'll be cut to shreds

THE NARRATOR

A crown of glass rocks there: a dollop
Left by the manufacturer's streaming sheet
Once derided as low class
Now priceless to the aesthete

MAXIM *(typing)* [_NEWS REPORT_]

Sachem, take a look at this…

THE NARRATOR

The helicopter buzzes around the smoke-tree's skirt [_HELICOPTER_]
Like a bee in a dark fir
The fire's holly-leaves are printed onto the canal
Like a folded paint-book
A Rorschach of the underworld, on Plane Street's night of Judgement
Dawn, Tony, Lyle and Aisha
Finally surge out of the front door

DAWN *(to others)*

He's still in there…I'm going back in

LYLE

No, too dangerous

THE NARRATOR

Peter remains inside, Lizzie twirling around him
Gathering crystals, relics
Rescuing Dawn's archives of wisdom from oblivion
Her holy texts and scriptures
Mayan prophecies carried out of a burning city
Fire sirens arrive now [_SIRENS_]
Aquarium'ing the grass around the pub with red and blue tropical fish
Throwing up cherry scents on the nettled walls
By now the flames have invaded next door
Into *Plane Street Dojo's* stockless cadaver
Resuscitating the dead shop with pumpkin light
From there they quickly leap onto *Sensations* roof
Flaring its torn swamp of verandah
Its window pigeon-feathered with Alice's flyers

MAXIM *(watching)*

It's a miracle

THE NARRATOR

Blanketed and checked for burns
The four watch fire engines arc water-lances into the crawling blaze

Mountains of coloured flame dye the sky
In an aurora of escaping pain, a bonfire of relics
Conflagrations of histories and yeast
A wicker-man of London elders
A rare civilisation turning against its gods, toppling statues
Native hexes released like an unexploded bomb disturbed from sleep
A Virginian princess stirs in her sarcophagus

LYLE

Look, here he is!

THE NARRATOR

Peter is hauled out of the pub by masked firemen
Smoke-stained and wheezing, Lizzie wrapped in a foil blanket
He clutches the half burnt deck, the smashed crystals
A stack of his own papers.

XXVIII. ???

[_NIGHT OWLS, PENCIL WRITING_]

THE NARRATOR

From *A History Of Plane Street and Its Environs*
By Captain P. Sloe

PETER *(reading)* [_CANAL WATER GENTLE_]

The first mention of the locale now known as Plane Street
Appears, where else, but in the Domesday Book
Where a small parish is listed under the name *Walnes*
The prefix *Wal-* denoting an area of Celtic presence, as in *Wales*
A term perhaps preserved only to this day
In the name of the longstanding Walnes Tavern pub
(Rendered more recently as the *Queen of Wands* by its proprietor -
Closed for refurbishment at the time of writing)

LIZZIE

Ruffffff!

PETER *(goes on)*

The area had always been a significant point in the traffic of effluent
From Medieval London down to the Thames, its waterways
Today forming the canal and basin network at Cinnamon Dock
The latter rebranded recently by New Romans Developments
(Swapping *Soil's Town* for a more aromatic moniker)
As cesspits and dells often do, Walnes became the natural home

Of London's magicians and madmen, no-marks and ne'erdowells

LIZZIE

Ruff! Ruff!

PETER *(feeding)*

Alright, twisted my arm… [_DOG BOWL, FOOD_]
Meanwhile the salubrious estates of Hilltop and Whittingham Park
Were established, by one merchant and missionary Sir John Plane
Who left London for Virginia Colony in the not-yet-United-States
Sometimes in the 1600s

LIZZIE *(eating)*

Rrurrruurrruurrrruur

PETER *(whispering now)*

And legend has it
There he met a princess of the *Nansemond* tribe
A woman of incredible charisma and beauty
Plane brought her back to London to marry
And *Nancy*, as she has been nicknamed by Plane Street locals
Has been invoked in range of guises ever since
From a council estate to a chip shop to a local vigilante activist
And she is doubly rumoured to have converted to Christianity here
Lived, borne children and died in this London of contrasts
Or returned home to her red-wooded shores of many Gods
One thing's certain, however: after successive waves of pagans,
Romans, Christians
If Nancy *is* buried under our thoroughfare
A curse might explain the seeming imperviousness to development
The survival, against all odds, of our Plane Street.

LIZZIE *(snoring)*

Zzzzzzz…zzzzzzzz

PETER *(to himself)*

But for how much longer?

XXIX. The Sun

[_BIRDS, BREEZE_]

THE NARRATOR

A sleet of ash
Blows over Plane Street and its environs

A nuclear wind
Emanating from its broken reactor's music
In the leaden safe-room of the *Queen of Wands*
Glimmers of birdsong squeak poignantly
As the sun frosts over the basin and *Five Acres Cemetery*
Soldering the canal
Like the grooves in Lyle's circuitboards
A metal sky pewtering the leaves in the precinct Planes
Rusting the red wrists of brambles

HELCOPTER INTERCOM [_PASSING CHOPPER_]
Yes, all clear to begin
Returning to tower, over

THE NARRATOR
The helicopter returns to its roost
The graffiti vigilante went unidentified
This year's fireworks went off without incident
But the smell of doom loiters on injured Plane Street
Peter is treated for smoke inhalation
Kept two nights at the *Great Road Hospital* for observation
While Lizzie, miraculous as ever, stays with Aisha and Lyle
When they let him out
He comes round to pick up his companion

PETER *(charitably)*
Come on *Sloe* sometime, we'll take her upstream
Out of London

LYLE
We'd love that, wouldn't we?

AISHA
Oh yes
A change is good as a rest
THE NARRATOR
He leaves them festooning her doorway
Like a wrought-gate of lovers
He returns with Lizzie to the boat
Cold and chalky, he watches pylons reflected in the canal zigzag
Like the cardiograms he had watched in hospital
A musical score of a life running out, goes back to his histories
Meanwhile in civilian clothes
Tony 2 drives back to the English coast, rain spearing the windows of his car

TONY *(singing)*

If I don't see her each day I miss her
Of gee what a thrill, just to kiss her

THE NARRATOR

He outruns Plane Street's gravity and associated ghosts
For the last time, scaling the Great Road's saturnine rings
Following the path of Azram, as Moscow money hits their accounts

MAXIM *(reading)*

PL NE STRE T DOJ O

THE NARRATOR

Fire-redacted letters are dropped and scrapped
Like those in an old London accent
With the ice cream shop and the dojo bought, the pub condemned
Hard-hatted Maxim arrives with surveyors to engage war
He plots where to strike in a theatre of demolition
How to dismantle this atomic font
This dormant, buried neutron swamp
This mutant stump on primordial London marsh

MAXIM *(on phone)*

Ok Mr Romans, we begin drilling now

THE NARRATOR

And what becomes of Dawn? The fish bones of her tale twisted up
Discarded and carted away like *Sensations* ruined ship
She vanishes between the threshold of dimensions
Into her domain of smokes and mirrors
Seen only in clouds twisting
Or maybe she just waits at home, tobacco'd, defeated
A card-less and blind armchair clairvoyant

DAWN *(trying to read)*

'The W…'
'World?'

THE NARRATOR

But as Maxim and the Romans explore that lode of roots, prying
Into the safe-room with jackhammers, into that uranium mangrove
Whose half-life protected the endangered species of a flowery slum
Dawn feels every prod and test, every hammer-blow and probe
Like voodoo in her own foundations as she sits
They send a seismogram through her, a wave of searching sound

That senses a hollow under the pub's heart
Something organic, the density of bone
Dawn holds her breath as they probe deeper, excavating the cellar
She jerks in her chair, work ceases, tools drop, they stand back

MAXIM

Pizdec!! Shit!

THE NARRATOR

Unknown bones, undated, unsexed, forming a vital forcefield
Was it the plot of a London pauper or
Perhaps the lost tomb of Nancy? A protective hex
Like the damp blue beer light, bathes the gorges of the cellar.

XXX. The World

[_GREAT ROAD_]

THE NARRATOR

The chronicle, with its fish-bone tangents ends here
A nominal North Pole
An inconsequential spot
Where an avenue of puss-laden drumsticks of trees
Leads to the jurassic cliffs of the Great Road
And under their deafened fringe of shrubs
A tiny, nameless green
This is the place where London's compass spins idly
Where its physics crash and its mind frays
It is unmarked, just a blown, tonsured patch of grass

ALICE

Robbers of the world, having by their universal plunder
Exhausted the land, they rifle the deep

THE NARRATOR

It could be the final resting place of Nancy
Or the dark spur of street where two lovers meet
A spiritualist landlady could be sitting in that marine living room there
Or here could be where a bohemian girl shared a pond-cold kiss
On this particle of the capital
A racecar'd nephew could brood on its plasticene beach
Or Plane Street's most disjointed son (me)
Could stand on its grass, eyes closed and commune
With London Minor, all its sacred sites

Its totalled margins seeming to align
I taste roads cherried with brake lights
Smell the vitality of adolescent parties on the breeze
Feel the heartbeat of bridge shaking over the Road
See foxes taxidermy'd by fear, a premonition of headlights in their eyes [_FOXES_]
Glimmers of rain on my affluent cheeks

ALICE

If the enemy be rich, they are rapacious
If he be poor, they lust for dominion

THE NARRATOR

It began in Whittingham Park [_PLAYGROUND_]
In my school of flaking privilege, like its radiators and hairy carpets
Classrooms foreign'd with faces
A mist entered my soul even then
Of Autumned girls on dire avenues
The sadness of coaches zooming away
That was one of my boats
Glossed and pompous in its river stance
The other was like *Sloe Gin*
Eel'd with canal grease, funny as mud, throaty with Plane wood
Brimming with truth
I have stood for a lifetime between the spreading boats
Straddling identities diverging precariously

ALICE

To robbery, slaughter, plunder, they give the lying name of empire
Where they make a desert, they call it peace

THE NARRATOR

Out of the dawn, a molten blue milk imitating a summer sky
The calligraphy of damson trees against it
Like vertical lines of Japanese
On the houses off the Great Road
Aerials all point like converts in the same direction
To where a plane trail's hem widens in the sky [_PLANES_]
Hydraulic questions fizz in my heels, wind intensifies [_WIND_]
Carrying enticing compounds of love, of fear, of never quite knowing
Errant rockets sparkle, synapses in a winter-bare tree brain [_FIREWORKS_]
I feel the vacuum in my soul from my home, all to this meaningless green
A firework rising in the airspace somewhere in between. [_FADE TO SILENCE_]

THE END